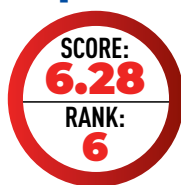


support split tunneling, it does so only on the Android app and not the Windows client. Users do not have the option of availing a dedicated IP address. The kill switch is a check box that can be toggled on or off. With 1300 servers in 55 countries, IPVanish offers a fair number of servers, but is on the lower end of the scale when it comes to the number of countries that these many servers are available in. IPVanish has apps on all the major platforms, as well as a plugin for Chrome. The pricing tiers are simple, with only monthly and yearly options available, as well as the standard 30 day money back guarantee. However, the pricing is



on the higher side. IPVanish does not support payments through any of the cryptocurrencies, and additionally users can only purchase the service through a credit card or PayPal. When it came to the speedtests, IPVanish did reasonably well when it came to streaming, but struggled a lot when it came to torrenting. For regular internet usage though, we found that the speed drop off was not much after using the VPN service. After StrongVPN, IPVanish had the lowest memory footprint among all the services that we tested, so the Windows client is definitely lean and mean. Despite being a low memory consumption app, the software is fairly advanced, with sophisticated features and control options. One of the best things about IPVanish is that it is ideal for large families or those with many devices, as each account supports unlimited simultaneous connections, one of the two services in our shortlist to do so.

ExpressVPN



ExpressVPN is based in the Virgin Islands, a decision taken to restrict access to the data by any government agencies. The Virgin Islands is not part of any of the Eyes intelligence communities. While it does not have a warrant canary, it does publish very detailed transparency reports, and is one of the few services in the list to have their operations externally audited, so the no logs policy can be taken seriously in this case at least. ExpressVPN does not offer a static IP address. ExpressVPN supports a

number of protocols and provides granular options for users to pick these protocols in a dedicated tab on the settings window. With 3000 servers in 94 countries, ExpressVPN has a pretty extensive network. Not only does ExpressVPN have apps for all the major platforms, they also have plugins for all the browsers, and the only one on the list to have a plugin for the obscure but feature-rich Vivaldi, as well as the privacy-oriented Brave. When it comes to payment methods, there are not too many options available, but there is support for Bitcoin payments. ExpressVPN uses a bunch of obfuscated servers, which naturally acts as a stealth mode, hiding the fact that the user is on a VPN service. ExpressVPN is serious about privacy, and follows a number of best practices in the industry. ExpressVPN is the cofounder of the VPN Trust Initiative

(VTI), and led the drafting of the VTI principles document which outlines the best practices a good VPN should follow. ExpressVPN is active in the advocacy of privacy and security through these initiatives.

Where ExpressVPN really shines is the speedtests. In fact, when compared to the base speeds, ExpressVPN saw the least amount of speed reduction in comparison to all the other VPNs that we tested. It is one of the few services that offers high speeds while both torrenting and streaming. There is no cap on the bandwidth. However, ExpressVPN only supports five simultaneous connections at a time, which can be a bit of a pain for families, or those with a large number of devices.

ExpressVPN uses a custom protocol that it has developed known as Lightway, which is oriented for speeds on devices that are perpetually connected to the internet. One of the design considerations of the protocol was to use less battery on low power devices, such as phones and laptops, so the codebase is incredibly lightweight. This not only ensures a reliable connection, but also that you can connect to a VPN server faster with a device. This feature is incredibly useful in making sure, for example, that you do not drop off a Discord call if there is a brief interruption in your internet connectivity, as the VPN service connects rapidly as soon as the internet connectivity is restored.

One of the incredibly useful features of the app is an integrated speedtest, that quickly lets you check the speeds to a number of servers, enabling you to choose the best one. This feature is great for figuring out the best servers for using a particular streaming service. Instead of a small window expanding to a big window for tweaking the settings, like most

